



Egyptian Bird Masks

Grade 6
Cut Paper



Los Altos School District • 201 Covington Road • Los Altos • CA • 94024 • 650.947.1195
www.losaltosartdocents.org

Last Revised: March 2022

EGYPTIAN BIRD MASKS

Length: 75 minutes

Number of docents: 1

Purpose:

- To view a number of reproductions to learn the cultural significance of birds depicted in Egyptian art.
- To understand the physical and decorative characteristics of birds and the various art elements found in Egyptian art. Emphasis will be placed on color, contrast, line, shape, pattern, repetition, and symmetry. Egyptian design elements will be examined.
- To learn the physical characteristics of constructing a mask patterned after birds. Students will learn to create the illusion of three dimension by using paper layering techniques and line embellishment.

Academic Support: Social Studies Curriculum Study of Ancient Egypt

Visual Arts Standards:

- Formulate an artistic investigation of personally relevant content for creating art. (6.VA:Cr1.2)
- Demonstrate openness in trying new ideas, materials, methods, and approaches in making works of art and design. (6.VA:Cr2.1)
- Reflect on whether personal artwork conveys the intended meaning and revise accordingly. (6.VA:Cr3)
- Identify and interpret works of art or design that reveal how people live around the world and what they value. (6.VA:Re7.1)
- Analyze how art reflects changing times, traditions, resources, and cultural uses. (6.VA:Cn11)

Unit Contains: Supply box and portfolio

Materials docent will bring:

- Display masks
- Egyptian Motif poster
- 12" x 18" turquoise, dark blue, red and black paper for docent demonstration
- Approximately 3" square sheets and scraps of gold paper
- 35 gold marking pens
- 35 black Sharpies
- White, black, blue and red Cray-pas
- 1 or 2 glue sticks
- 35 small pointed scissors
- Masking tape

Materials teacher will provide:

- 2 sheets of 12” x 18” construction paper for each student and additional sheets for embellishment in assorted sheets of turquoise, dark blue, red and black
- Glue sticks
- Pencils
- Additional gold pens, if available

Featured works:

<i>KING TUT MUMMY MASK</i> , 1333-1323 BCE	from the Tomb of Tutankhamun
<i>EGYPT</i> , Wall painting, 1304-1307 BCE	from the Tomb of Queen Nefertari
<i>PAPYRUS OF HUNEFER</i> , circa 1275 BCE	From the tomb of Hunefer
<i>HORUS GOD FALCON STATUE</i> , 246-222 B.C.	from the Temple of Edfu
<i>JEWELLED FALCON</i> , 1333-1323 BCE	
<i>PECTORAL</i> , 1333-1323 BCE	from the Tomb of Tutankhamun

NOTES TO DOCENTS

- Emphasize the art elements of line, shape (especially chevron), pattern, design, realistic, stylized, rigid, repetition, overlapping and symmetry.
- Use the term “beak”—a beak is not a nose.
- Walk around the room with reproductions that have small detail.
- Display reproductions and masks.
- Draw diagrams on the board. (See suggested diagrams in demonstration portion)
- Save gold paper scraps for future lessons.
- Remind students to shake pens with caps on.
- Minimize the use of Cray-pas, placing emphasis on cut paper and embellishing with pens. Offer only to students experiencing difficulty cutting or for small areas of embellishment.
- Allow at least 50 minutes for making masks.
- **Take special care of display masks as they are very fragile!**

Consider starting class with a gallery walk with all artworks on display around the classroom

INTRODUCTION (5 minutes)

Today we are making bird masks in an Egyptian style, using the colors, patterns and art elements that the Ancient Egyptians used. We will first look at some examples of Ancient Egyptian art for inspiration.

As you look around the room you see many examples of ancient Egyptian art.

Almost everyone can instantly recognize Egyptian art. What makes it so easy? Can you describe what makes Egyptian art so distinctive?

- *Colors*

- *Figures flat and in profile*
- *Rigidity*
- *Stylized vs. realistic*
- *Patterns – chevrons, bars, triangles, etc.*
- *Symbols*

Much of Egyptian art was made to adorn tombs and typically reserved for the wealthy. Tomb art often represented scenes from one's life on earth so that one's spirit would be able to recall it and be guided into the afterlife. Thus a large amount of ancient Egyptian art was never intended to be seen publicly, and the artists themselves were typically unknown.

Egyptian art includes ivory sculptures, paintings, papyrus drawings, ceramics, and jewelry. Additionally, Egypt is famous for its ancient architecture; its pyramids and temples.

DISCUSSION (15 minutes)

KING TUT MUMMY MASK, 1333-1323 BCE

from the *Tomb of Tutankhamun*

Gold Alloy

Suggested dialog:

Besides the pyramids at Giza in Egypt, King Tut's mummy mask is probably one of the most famous Egyptian works of art. King Tutankhamen's tomb was discovered in 1922. The discovery was special as the tomb was previously undiscovered and therefore fully intact. Over 3,000 treasures were encapsulated in the tomb, all to help the young King Tutankhamen in his afterlife. The walls of the burial chamber were painted with scenes of his voyage to the afterworld.



What can you observe about Egyptian art in King Tut's funeral mask?

- Beautiful gold work – 22 pounds of gold in the mask!
- Design symmetry
- Stone inlay – lapis lazuli, carnelian, obsidian, turquoise and glass paste
- Vulture and cobra headaddress – Cobra symbolizes Lower Egypt and vulture Upper Egypt; together they represent Tut's rule of the whole country.
- Note the heavy lines around the eyes. This is common in Egyptian art. As a hieroglyph, the stylized eye meant protection and was used in descriptions about the pharaoh.

Introduce Egyptian birds with this suggested dialog:

Birds played an important part in the lives of Ancient Egyptians. Seasonal migrations over Egypt resulted in large flocks of birds along the Nile River. Birds inspired Egyptian craftspeople and artisans. Avian motifs were common on palace walls as well as incorporated into common useful objects like vases and bowls. They were also preserved on tomb walls both depicted in daily life as well as elevated as gods and goddesses.

EGYPT, 19th Dynasty, 1304-1307 BCE

from the Tomb of Queen Nefertari
Wall painting



Suggested dialog:

As you have/are studying, the ancient Egyptians worshipped many gods, including gods represented by birds. The most important bird was the falcon god Horus, which became associated with the Pharaoh. This tomb wall painting shows Horus. The symbol of the Sun God Ra appears over his head.

- Do you recognize the head of a falcon?
- How do you describe its beak? *sharp, hooked beak of bird of prey*
- Is it realistic or stylized?
- The falcon god holds an ankh, a symbol of life, both on earth and in the afterlife.

PAPYRUS OF HUNEFER, circa 1275 BCE

From the tomb of the royal scribe Hunefer



Suggested dialog:

This ancient Egyptian funerary manuscript written on papyrus consists of magic spells intended to assist a dead person's journey through the underworld and into the afterlife.

How many different birds and other Egyptian symbols can you see in this papyrus scroll?

- *Falcon, ibis with extended beak and flying duck*
- *Ankh*
- *Lotus*
- *Various birds and animals in hieroglyphics*

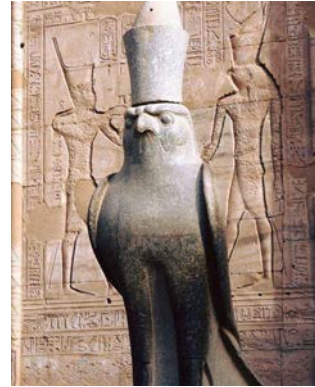
HORUS GOD FALCON STATUE, 246-222 B.C.

from the Temple of Edfu

Granite statuary

Suggested dialog:

This granite statue of the falcon god Horus stands at the Temple of Edfu which is an Egyptian temple located on the Nile River, and is one of the best-preserved shrines in Egypt.



- Does this statue look like the same bird as in the wall painting?
- What makes the falcon look so fierce? *big eye with a yellow ring and the beak*

JEWELLED FALCON, 1333-1323 BCE

PECTORAL, 1333-1323 BCE

from the Tomb of Tutankhamun

Cloisonné jewelry

Suggested dialog:

These are pieces of bird themed jewelry from King Tut's tomb made of gold inlaid with semiprecious stones and blue glass paste. The combination is called cloisonné. We can see both a falcon, as well as Nekhabet, the vulture goddess, another bird commonly used in Egyptian beliefs and art. You will remember that the vulture and cobra adorn King Tut's funeral mask.



- Take a moment to look at the wonderful patterns on the wings.
- How would you describe the patterns? *rigid, repetitive pattern, overlapping of feathers and patterns, chevron shape, soft vs. sharp, angle of wings*
- Do you see any new shapes or patterns in the vulture pectoral? *square, triangle, a design from the leaf of a lotus flower*
- What about the beak and eye? Is it the same as on the falcon? *beak is longer, not as sharp and the eye does not have a large ring of another color*
- What about colors? These are the colors you will use to make your masks.
- Except for the head, everything on the bird designs are symmetrical.

These pieces of jewelry, as well as the other pieces we have looked at today, can serve as inspiration for your own bird masks. Remember that the Egyptians used lots of color and design elements, so don't hold back on the details on your masks!

DEMONSTRATION (5 minutes)

Planning, Folding and Drawing

Imagine how your mask will look. Will it have a long or short beak, a large feathery shape, or maybe upswept wings?

You will be making your mask extra sturdy by using two sheets of paper glued together.

Choose one color for the front and another for the back, which will be the color of the beak and maybe decorations around the eye and edge.

Remind students the only colors they will use are turquoise, dark blue, red, black, and gold found in Egyptian cloisonné.

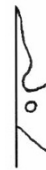
If you are making a mask with a **long** beak, fold both sheets in half lengthwise, or hot dog fold. This will give you a narrower face.

If you are making a mask with a **short** beak, a wide face, or a large mask, fold the sheets in half widthwise, or hamburger fold.

With your pencil, draw the outline of the head and beak. Start with the beak, which you will draw upwards and will be folded down when you are finished cutting. Start partway down the folded edge of your paper, at least two finger's width from the fold and draw your beak up to the top of your paper. Be creative with your beak shape!



Return your pencil to the starting point and draw the outline of your mask. Make it as big as possible so you have lots of space to add details and designs.



Cutting

Shape: When you are satisfied with your outline, place one sheet inside the other and cut out the shape. When you are done, if the shape doesn't look the way you want it, you can make adjustments by cutting away paper from one or both sheets of paper.

Eyes: About 3 fingers (~1 1/2") from the fold, use your pencil to mark a spot for the center of the eyes. With the sheets folded, cut out a small opening through one of both paper layers.

Embellishing

When you embellish your mask, think about the art elements and Egyptian design elements: line, pattern and design, shapes (chevron, feather, lotus), repetition, symmetry, and contrasting color as well as stylized and rigid designs

You will want each side of your mask to look symmetrical. When you add a design element, make sure you add it to each side. It's really helpful to fold a piece of paper in half and cut through both pages to create two identical shapes.

There are lots of great options for decorating your mask.

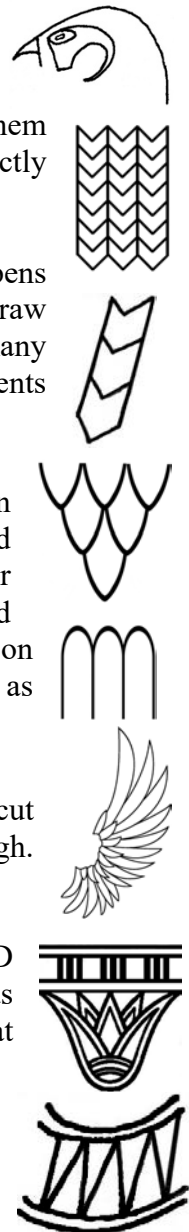
Eye design: Using gold pens, or perhaps black Sharpies, embellish the eye area with creative outlining. You may also cut out the shape or cut decorative designs, like the design on the jeweled falcon, and glue them around the eye. Cutting out the shape will assure that your eyes are exactly identical. White Cray-pas can be used for coloring the white of the eye.

Line design: For fine lines, use a gold pen or black Sharpie. Use gold pens sparingly; they are not for filling in large spaces. You can use them to draw or embellish small decorative patterns. To minimize the cutting of many small shapes to make a pattern, cut a large shape and divide into segments with pen lines

Adding cut-outs: You can cut out decorative shapes and layer or even overlap them to create patterns and designs. These might be stylized shapes like the chevron and feathers we see on the Egyptian cloisonné or feathers like the ones on the wings of a falcon. Alternate colors and patterns, using contrasting colors. Insert gold shapes or glue other colors on top of gold paper. This add-on technique allows you to glue each piece as you proceed. (Remind students of the repetition and angle of feathers.)

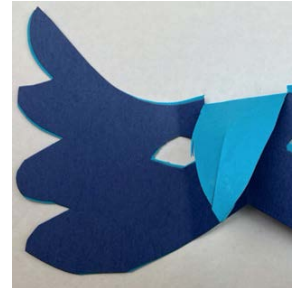
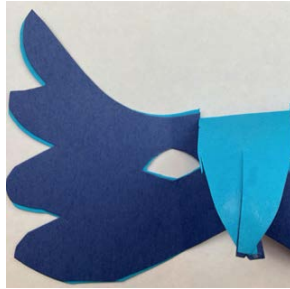
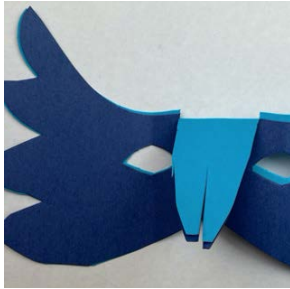
Subtracting cut-outs: The opposite of the add-on technique would be to cut out shapes from the top paper, allowing the back color to show through. Glue the top piece down when you have finished cutting.

Scoring: You can overlap a cluster of feathers and score them to give a 3D appearance. Cut out a feather and score or crease the feather so that it bends out somewhat. Overlap and glue down the feathers remembering that number of feathers get smaller at the center.



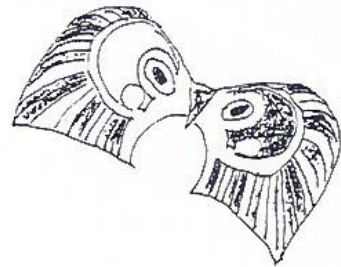
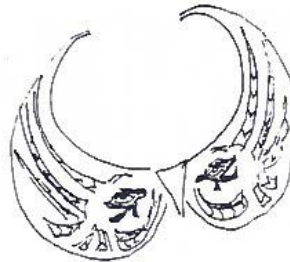
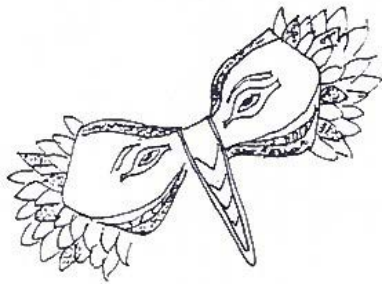
Finishing

Beak: Fold the beak over and decorate. To make an optional 3-dimensional beak, Cut a slit up the middle of the pointed end of the beak approximately 1 ½ inches long. Then overlap one side of the paper on top of the other and glue in place to make the beak bulge out. You may need to trim the ends.



Gluing: When you have completed all the decorations, make sure everything is securely glued.

AFTER THE DEMONSTRATION, DISTRIBUTE PAPER TO THE STUDENTS.



BACKGROUND

Birds, Art, & Myth of Egypt

Ancient Egyptian Art

(<https://australian.museum/learn/cultures/international-collection/ancient-egyptian/art-in-ancient-egypt/>)

Ancient Egyptian art has survived for over 5000 years and continues to fascinate people from all over the world. An ancient premise has become a modern reality: art is a path to eternal remembrance.

In ancient Egypt, art was magical. Whether in the form of painting, sculpture, carving or script, art had the power to maintain universal order and grant immortal life by appealing to various gods to act on behalf of people – both in life and in death.

Art was everywhere. From 4500, BCE Egypt's symbolic art was an essential part of public buildings such as temples and palaces. Widely understood symbols formed the basis of this art as it was believed that these offered protection from evil influences in this life and the next. It is no surprise then that art was also a crucial inclusion in the elaborate tombs that housed the mummified remains of people.

Tomb art

Tomb art was considered the point of contact between the land of the living and the land of the dead. If certain formulas for the creation of art were followed and the right gods supplicated, all Egyptians from the wealthy to the poor could look forward to completing their earthly life, successfully navigating the dangerous underworld and traversing to the blessed, eternal afterlife.

Egyptian tombs were like secret art galleries that were never meant to be viewed. Instead, these amazing examples of artistic craftsmanship spoke only to an elite group of visitors – the gods.

Artistic style

When representing human figures in a piece of tomb art, it was important to show as much of the body to the gods as possible. That is why both frontal and profile views of a body were integrated into one figure. It wasn't meant to be naturalistic; it was intended to serve as a sign that stood for 'human'. This method helped the gods recognize the person and also made the figure a recipient for ritual activity.

Kings were portrayed larger than life to symbolize the ruler's god-like powers and therefore importance in the afterlife. Similarly, tomb owners, as the most important subject of the design in their tomb, were depicted on a grand scale. In contrast, wives and children, servants and animals were drawn smaller, indicating their lesser importance.

Color

Color was seen as a kind of universal language that was used to communicate significant meaning to the Egyptian gods. Certain colors were imbued with specific powers or attributes that were linked to various gods. As a result, great power could be contained within an object if it was made or painted in meaningful colors. For example, green and blue were the colors of plants, water and sky and symbolized fertility and prosperity. Gold was the color of the sun and of the gods' skin and was linked to immortality.

Hieroglyphs

The most direct way that a tomb owner could communicate with the gods was through the elaborate Egyptian hieroglyph system. These pictograms performed a very specific function – to ensure certain gods were supplicated and rituals performed for all eternity. Hieroglyphs were written in both columns and rows and could be read from either the left or the right, depending on the design of the text.

Birds in Egyptian Art

(<https://joycefiler.wordpress.com/2013/03/29/birds-in-ancient-egyptian-society-some-brief-notes-2/>)

The ancient Egyptians were keen observers of the world around them, especially the fauna (and flora) and so they employed all manner of creatures, which they observed in their environment, in their artwork and in their hieroglyphic writing system. Research suggests that more than seventy species of birds can be seen in ancient Egyptian art. The wide range of birds in Egyptian art, preserved remains and textual references clearly indicate that the people of Egypt encountered many species of birds and that these birds played an important role in ancient Egyptian society.

Falcons are probably the most frequently represented bird in ancient Egyptian contexts. Modern tourists arriving in the Temple of Edfu cannot but help notice the magnificent statues of the god Horus, in the form of a falcon, standing proudly in the temple precincts. Egypt is home to various species of vulture and these are easily identified in Egyptian artistic sources. Vultures are particularly associated with two protective goddesses: Nekhbet, who gave protection principally to the king of Egypt and also to his subjects and Nut, the sky goddess. The ibis was associated with Thoth, the god of wisdom, learning and writing. Waterfowl, including wild and domestic species of ducks and geese, were popular food, and were often incorporated into Egyptian art – on tomb ceilings and as cosmetic unguent holders.

Objects used in the designs/patterns of Egyptian Art:

- **Lotus** represents spiritual enlightenment and is often intertwined with a papyrus reed. It is the symbol of Upper Egypt.
- **Papyrus** is Tree of Life and symbol of Lower Egypt.
- **Scarab** represents resurrection and the **Serpent** Wadjet is goddess of Lower Egypt, (guardian / forceful defense).

- **Sacred feather** and **plumed crown**. The crown of Lower Egypt is red and Upper Egypt is white.
- **Birds** and their **feathers** include the falcon (Horus), vulture (Nekhabet, goddess of Upper Egypt and guardian /motherly defense), heron (Phoenix Bird), ibis (Thoth), goose, duck, owl, ostrich, swallow and chick.
- **Animals** included the dog, bull, lion, rabbit, ram, jackal, and cat.
- **Sacred Eye of Horus** (guardian) the **Crook** and **Flail** (emblems of power), **Ankh** (key of life or Nile) and the round shape of the **Sun**, beads, and grapes.
- The **Colors**, Black, White, and Red, were considered the three primary colors of the Western World during this period. Blue had beneficent powers and appeared on funerary objects, as Egyptians believed it protected the dead, brought good luck, and was associated with green the color of resurrection. Blue pigments often changed to green and blue-green tones due to the properties of copper. Occasionally, Green appeared on wall paintings.

Gem stones and materials used in Egyptian Art:

- Red and beige/yellow **limestone** from Lower Egypt. Very soft, plaster surfaces were covered with mud from the Nile, white washed, and then painted. Sandstone came from Upper Egypt.
- **Granite** came from the Western Desert, alabaster, and ivory from other countries.
- Masks were first cast in plaster and then cast in **gold**. Wood was covered with gold leaf. Gold was found in the Nubian Desert/Southern Egypt and Northern Sudan and in the Eastern Desert/Sinai Peninsula.
- **Carnelian**, a quartz, was mined in the Western Desert, el tar/tur Sinai/ Saudi Arabia, and arrived from Afghanistan along the ancient trade route from China. Heat, used in the mining, changes its color.
- **Turquoise** was mined in the Sinai.
- **Lapis Lazuli** from Iran and Afghanistan is a hard stone with gold (pyrite) veins. Lapis sometimes arrived in paste form, which was then glazed to look like glass. Because of the expense, Lapis was used in small amounts for funerary pieces such as statuettes, figurines, and beads. Lapis was the only blue pigment used by painters. Often interchangeable with sapphires, it was believed to bring good luck, and, along with the color green, brought magical powers and resurrection.
- **Indigo** color was made from ground limestone mixed with sand and a copper-containing mineral, such as azurite or malachite, which was then heated to a high temp. The result was an opaque blue glass which then had to be crushed and combined with thickening agents such as egg whites to create a long-lasting paint or glaze.
- **Copper silicates**, mined as carbon copper (derived from Malachite) in the Eastern Desert of Nubia along the Nile and in Sinai, was made into paste and used for faience, glass beads, etc.
- **Amethyst**, a quartz, was mined in the Eastern Desert.
- **Emeralds** were light green and found along the Nile.

Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
1995	Bonnie Sorenson	Developed as part of 25 th anniversary celebration
1998	Bonnie Sorenson	
April 2011	Kimberly Dickerson	Reformatted for continuity
February 2013	Curriculum Committee	Added suggestions for docents to give feedback to children
May 2014	Curriculum Committee	Time changed to 75 minutes
November 2015	Curriculum Committee	Suggestions for timing added
May 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	New VAPA Standards added
February 2022	Stephanie Dauer	More concentrated on Egyptian Art